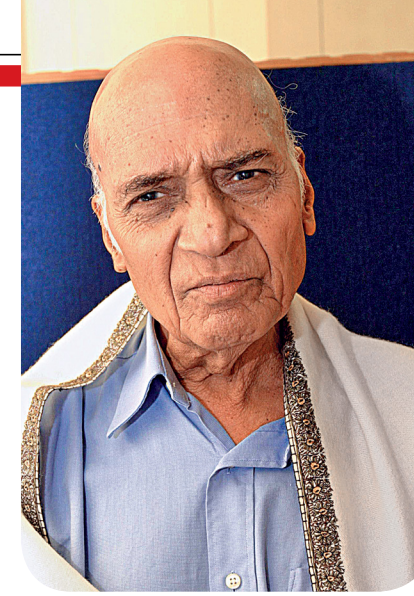
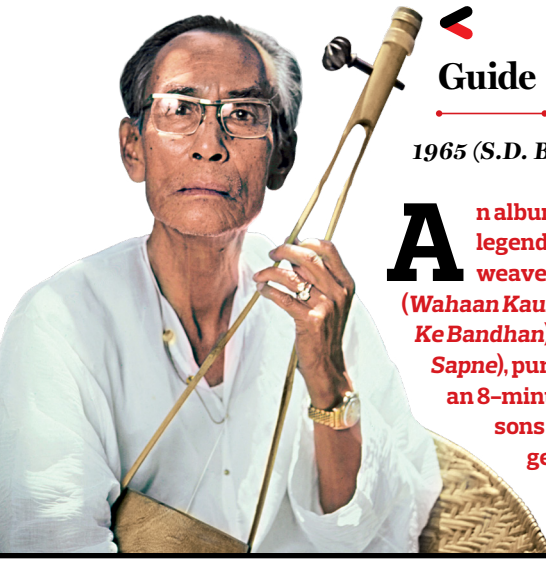


Hum Dono

1961 (Jaidev)

Jaidev is probably the most underrated genius in Hindi film music history, mainly because his work got lost in ordinary or low-budget parallel films few people cared for—*Jumbish*, *Gaman*, *Do Boond Paani* and *Gharonda* being cases in point. But the one time he scored for a big-budget film with big stars, he gave us gems like *Main Zindagi Ka Saath*, *Abhi Na Jaao* and Lata Mangeshkar's popular ode to secularism—the bhajan *Allah Tero Naam*—all penned by Sahir Ludhianvi, who was at the top of his craft.



Guide

1965 (S.D. Burman)

An album of great variety, crafted by legends. S.D. Burman and Shailendra weave ballads of existential longing (*Wahaan Kaun Hai Tera*), iconoclasm (*Tod Ke Bandhan*), togetherness (*Tere Mere Sapne*), pure abandon (*Gaata Rahe*) and an 8-minute medley following the seasons of the heart (*Piya Tose*). SDB gets both Kishore and Rafi to sing for Dev Anand. That both suit him is part of the magic.

Umrao Jaan

1981 (Khayyam)

As Asha Bhosle sings *Kab Mili Thi, Kahaan Bichhdi Thi*, you feel the pain of a lost home—even from an imagined world. That's the magic of Khayyam and Shahryar's truly sublime work for Muzaffar Ali's period drama. Khayyam has created many stunning albums—take *Raziya Sultan* or *Bazaar*. But *Umrao Jaan*, loaded with ghazals, thumris and even an Amir Khusro *bidaai geet* (*Kaahe Ko Byaahe Bides*), tops my list because of the way Asha helms an entire album hinging on a philosophical matrix of longing, love and heartbreak.

Baiju Bawra

1952 (Naushad)

Years before *Mughal-E-Azam*, Naushad saab gave us a blueprint on how to parlay Hindustani classical into film music. *Baiju Bawra*, where a village singer challenges the great Tansen of Akbar's court, offered just the canvas for such a transmuting. With lyricist Shakeel Badayuni, Naushad creates a magnum opus: 13 tracks, many of them raga-based, five sung by Ustad Amir Khan, two by Pt D.V. Paluskar, the rest by Rafi and Lata. A most ambitious album, from the formative years of film music, it's a prototype the genre sadly kept a distance from.

Masoom

1983 (R.D. Burman)

Anup Ghoshal, Vanita Mishra, Gurpreet Kaur and Aarti Mukherjee might not have instant recall in the minds of Hindi film music lovers but they created the soundtrack of my childhood with my favourite R.D. Burman-Gulzar album. Yes, the two have collaborated on at least 10 other great films, but to have Do Naina, Huzoor Iss Kadar *and* Lakdi Ki Kathi *segueing into an inherently non-musical film was truly a work of genius minds.*

